

Babylon

How to Live When America Stops Being Christian

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LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

Build houses and live in them. Plant gardens and eat their produce... But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare.

— Jeremiah 29:5, 7

Chapter One: The Part of the Letter We Never Read

There is a verse from the prophet Jeremiah that you have seen on a coffee mug, a graduation card, a framed print in a Christian bookstore, a wall hanging in a church foyer. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. It is, by some measures, the single most quoted verse in the American church, and we have made it the most personal promise in the Bible, a private guarantee that my particular dreams are about to come true, that my future is bright, that God is arranging good things for me specifically. We did that, every one of us who has ever leaned on it that way, by performing a small act of surgery. We cut the verse free of the four verses that come before it, which almost no one reads, and which were written to people whose entire world had just been destroyed.

Go back and read what surrounds it, and the comfort changes color entirely. In 597 before Christ the armies of Babylon came against Jerusalem, and the city surrendered, and the conquerors did what conquerors did, marching the cream of the nation a thousand miles east into captivity, the king and the craftsmen and the soldiers and the leading families, leaving a puppet behind to keep the peace. A decade later, when the puppet rebelled, they came back and finished the work, breaking the walls, burning the temple, the actual dwelling place of God on earth, to the ground, and dragging away nearly everyone who was left. The people of God, who had believed their God would never let his own house fall, sat in the wreckage of every promise they thought they

understood, in a foreign empire that worshipped other gods and spoke another tongue and had every reason to despise them. And it was to those people, the first wave of exiles already in Babylon, grieving and disoriented and desperate to go home, that the prophet Jeremiah sent a letter.

The plans verse is the eleventh line of that letter. We treat it as the headline. In the letter it is almost the footnote, the reassurance attached to a far harder word, and the harder word is the one we have spent twenty-five centuries refusing to read. Because the first thing the letter does is take away the only hope the exiles wanted. There were prophets among them, men like Hananiah, telling the people exactly what their grief longed to hear, that the whole nightmare would be brief, that within two years God would shatter the yoke of Babylon and bring them all home and set the furniture back where it had been. And Jeremiah, in the name of the same God, called that a lie, and gave them a number instead, a number so cruel that no one selling hope has ever wanted to say it. Seventy years. A lifetime. Most of you will die here. Your grandchildren will see Jerusalem, not you. Settle in. The exile is not a weekend. It is the rest of your life, and your children's lives, and you had better learn how to live it.

And then, having taken away the fantasy of rescue, the letter does the truly shocking thing. It does not tell the exiles to fight, and it does not tell them to vanish. It tells them to live. Build houses and live in them. Plant gardens and eat what they produce. Take wives, have sons and daughters, find wives for your sons and give your daughters in marriage, multiply there and do not decrease. And then the line that should stop the heart of anyone who has ever felt their country slipping away from them. Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into

exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare. Build. Plant. Marry. Multiply. Seek. Pray. Six imperatives handed to a defeated people, commanding them not to wait out their captivity with their bags packed and not to dissolve into Babylon and forget who they were, but to do the third and stranger thing, to put down roots in the soil of the empire that had ruined them, and to seek its good.

I have written, in another book, the long argument for why this ancient letter is suddenly, urgently addressed to us, so I will not lay the whole case out again here. The short version is the thing most of the American church still cannot make itself say out loud. For sixteen hundred years, and in this country for most of four centuries, Christianity enjoyed an arrangement we have come to call Christendom, in which the faith was the assumed water everyone swam in, culturally established, socially respectable, woven so deeply into the civic furniture that you did not have to believe much of anything to be carried along by it. That arrangement is over. It is not coming back. And what died with it was never Christianity itself but only Christianity's cultural scaffolding, the borrowed power and the easy respectability, and the church has been weeping at the wrong funeral, mistaking the loss of its privileges for the loss of its God. We are exiles now, a moral and spiritual minority in a country that no longer shares our memory, and the sooner we stop waiting for the water to come back the sooner we can do what the exiles were commanded to do, which is to live, and live well, here.

Here is what I have come to believe, and what this whole book is an attempt to work out. A diagnosis, once you have it, is strangely useless. It tells you what happened. It tells you the water has drained, the arrangement has collapsed, the country

has moved on. It does not tell you how to get out of bed on Tuesday and be a Christian in the actual world that remains. And we have had a great deal of diagnosis. We have had the books and the conferences and the laments, the statistics about decline and the hand-wringing about the rising tide of the religiously unaffiliated, and all of it true, and almost none of it any help, because a person who knows only that they are in exile knows only that they are lost. The letter is the cure for that paralysis, because the letter does not stop at you are in exile. It keeps going, into the imperative mood, into verbs, into the unglamorous and load-bearing business of how an exile actually builds a life. This book is those verbs.

And the verbs turn on a single word, which is the reason the platform I write from carries the name it does. Seek the welfare of the city, God says, and in its welfare you will find your welfare. The word translated welfare, both times, is the Hebrew *shalom*, and *shalom* is not the thin thing we have reduced it to, not mere quiet or the absence of trouble or a private inner calm. It is wholeness, flourishing, the way things are supposed to be when they are right, a city where the hungry are fed and the stranger is safe and the work is honest and the weak are not crushed and the streets are at peace. God commands the exiles to seek that, not for Jerusalem, which is gone, but for Babylon, the very empire that burned their temple. And he binds their own flourishing to it, so tightly that the two cannot be pulled apart. You will not find your *shalom* by hoarding it behind a wall. You will find it, the only place it has ever been found, by spending it on the good of a city that is not your home and never will be.

That sentence is the whole argument of this book in miniature, and it cuts against the two answers the church keeps reaching for, the two answers the exiles themselves were tempted by and

Jeremiah forbade. There is the answer that wants to fight its way home, to take the country back by force, to seize the levers of culture and law and crank the old Christendom back into place, and there is the answer that wants to stop being different, to file down every offensive edge of the faith until it dissolves comfortably into the surrounding culture and the ache of being a stranger goes away. One wants to conquer Babylon. The other wants to become it. And the letter, with a kind of holy stubbornness, says no to both, and commands the harder, slower, stranger thing, which is to live as a faithful and distinct people inside a city you do not control, pouring yourself out for its good while bowing to none of its gods. I will spend a full chapter on why both of the easy answers fail, because the pull of them is enormous and I feel it myself, the longing for the old deference on one side and the longing for the clever world's approval on the other, and both of them are the flesh dressed up as faithfulness.

I will not pretend I am above any of this, because I am not. I want the water back as much as anyone who grew up assuming the room was on his side, and I was not even raised in the faith, so I have less excuse than most for the nostalgia I still catch in my own chest. I have reached for the fast answers. I have wanted the church to win in ways that have nothing to do with the cross. The man who learns to live well in exile is not a man who never felt the longing to go home. He is a man who heard the prophet say seventy years, and grieved it, and then picked up a shovel and planted a garden in the Babylonian dirt anyway, because that was what faithfulness looked like in the world as it actually was and not the world he wished he lived in. That is the whole vocation, and it is available to a church with no power at all, which is the only kind of church that has ever changed anything.

So let me hand you the letter, the way it was actually written, the

hard word and the strange commands and the buried promise that your welfare is hidden inside the welfare of a city you did not choose. We will start where the exiles had to start, with the grief, with what actually happened to the world that used to feel like home, because you cannot learn to live in Babylon until you can admit that Jerusalem is not coming to rescue you, and that the water, the warm and assumed and effortless water you were so sure was the faith itself, has already drained away into the sand.

Chapter Two: How the Water Drained

The hardest part of being an exile is the moment you realize you are one, because for a long time you do not feel exiled at all. You feel, instead, that something has gone wrong with the world, that the country has betrayed you, that forces you cannot name have stolen the home you were standing in. The grief comes before the understanding, and the grief looks around for someone to blame, the schools or the courts or the other party or the young, and it takes a long time and a great deal of honesty to arrive at the truer and stranger diagnosis, which is not that your home was stolen but that it was never quite your home in the way you thought. You were swimming in water you mistook for air, and the water has drained, and you are flopping on the sand, and the first work of the exile is simply to understand what has actually happened.

There is an old story about fish that has outlived its telling because it is true about more than it seems. Two young fish are swimming along, and an older fish passes them going the other way and says, morning, boys, how is the water, and the two young fish swim on a while, and finally one looks at the other and says, what is water. That is the whole problem with water. The fish cannot see it. It is not one feature of the world among others, it is the medium in which the fish lives and moves, the invisible given that makes everything else possible, and precisely because it is everywhere it is nowhere in particular, unnoticed, unnamed, assumed. American Christians spent so many generations swimming in a culture that was basically on their

side that they stopped experiencing it as a culture at all. It simply felt like reality. It felt like the way things are.

So let me try to make the water visible, because you cannot learn to live after Christendom until you can see the Christendom you are living after. It began, as a matter of history, with a Roman emperor and a battle. For its first three centuries the church had no political standing of any kind, an illegal and frequently hunted minority meeting in homes, and then Constantine won at the Milvian Bridge in 312 and issued an edict of toleration the next year, and called the bishops to Nicaea in 325, and within a single lifetime, under Theodosius in 380, the faith that Rome had fed to lions became the official religion of Rome. That is the hinge of Western history, the day the persecuted minority became the establishment, and it stayed the establishment, in one form or another, for sixteen hundred years, through the medieval synthesis and the Reformation and into the founding of a new nation across the sea that promised to do things differently.

And America did do things differently, in the narrow legal sense, and we should be glad of it. There was no state church, no bishop on the public payroll, no establishment of religion, and that disestablishment was a genuine good. But what we built in its place was subtler and in some ways stronger than any state church, a cultural establishment without a legal one, the faith woven so thoroughly into the civic furniture that no law was needed to enforce it. The schools opened in prayer. The stores closed on Sunday. The politicians quoted the King James whether they had read it or not, and ended their speeches asking God to bless the country and meant, roughly, the God the audience meant. The calendar bent itself around the Christian year. A pastor was a respected man in town and not a suspicious one. A person could be entirely faithless and still be carried his

whole life by a current that ran, unmistakably, in a Christian direction. That current was the water, and it held everyone up, the devout and the nominal and the unbeliever alike, for free.

And here is what the water did to us, the thing we are only now able to see because it has finally drained. It taught us, without ever saying so, that to be a Christian was to be central, normal, respectable, the home team, the majority that set the terms. It formed in us a whole set of expectations we mistook for the faith itself, the expectation that the institutions would defer to us, that the culture would assume us, that being a believer meant being an insider rather than a stranger. None of that is anywhere in the New Testament, which was written by and to a powerless minority under a hostile empire, but all of it felt, to us, like Christianity, because we had never known the faith in any other condition. We quietly folded the privileges of the arrangement into the gospel itself, until the two became impossible to tell apart, and losing the privileges came to feel exactly like losing the gospel.

You can watch the water drain in the numbers, and the numbers are not subtle. In the early 1970s about one American in twenty told a survey-taker he had no religion at all, a rounding error, a curiosity. By the 2020s it was approaching one in three, and the people who check the box marked none had become the single fastest-growing religious group in the country, larger than any denomination. That is not a dip in a cycle. That is a whole category of person who barely existed in your grandfather's America becoming one of the largest blocs in your children's. Whatever had been holding the old arrangement up stopped holding somewhere around the turn of this century, and the fall since has been steep, and there is no serious sign of it reversing, and a great deal of foolishness in the church right now comes

from people who refuse to believe the water is not about to come rushing back.

But a number like that hides the deeper change, which is not how many people left but what replaced the thing they left. The sociologist Robert Bellah saw it coming back in 1985, in a book called *Habits of the Heart*, where he interviewed a woman he called Sheila who described her religion in a sentence that ought to be carved over the door of this whole era. She said she believed in God, that she was not a religious fanatic, that she could not remember the last time she had been to church, that her faith had carried her a long way, and that it was her own faith, Sheilaism, just her own little voice. She had named her religion after herself, and Bellah understood that she was not a rebel but a prophet, the future arriving early. The self had quietly become the highest authority, the final court of appeal, and the church was demoted from the place you go to find the truth to one more resource you might consult on the way to deciding it for yourself. The therapeutic had replaced the confessional. The question had shifted from is it true to does it work for me, and a faith that makes demands does not survive that question for long.

Charles Taylor gave the whole condition its best name when he called ours a secular age, and he was careful to say he did not mean a world emptied of belief. He meant a world in which belief has become contestable, in which the faith that was once the unspoken floor beneath everyone's feet is now one option among many, a position a person takes knowing full well that the thoughtful people across the table have looked at the same evidence and chosen otherwise. That is a different kind of believing than the kind the water made possible. It is belief in the open sea, without the buoyancy, and a church that only ever knew how to float in the shallows of cultural assumption is going

to have to learn, quickly and at cost, how to swim.

We have been weeping at the wrong funeral. What died was not Christianity but Christendom, the scaffolding and not the building, and we mistook the scaffolding for the building because we had been told for so long that they were the same.

So here is the diagnosis, finally, stated plainly enough to build on. What is dying in America is not the Christian faith. It is cultural Christianity, the broad and shallow belief that the water held up for free, the kind of faith that cost nothing because the culture subsidized it, the nominal churchgoing and the vague civic religion and the assumption that decent people were more or less Christian. That faith was never converted. It was carried. And you cannot mourn the loss of a faith that was only ever the buoyancy of the water. The real church, the one with roots, the one that costs something, the one that was never the majority and never needed to be, is still standing in the drained room, smaller than the shadow the water made it look, and for the first time in a long time unmistakably itself. We are not watching the death of the church. We are watching the end of its long holiday from being a minority, and the question now is whether we will spend our strength trying to flood the room again, or whether we will do the harder and holier thing, and learn at last to live.

Chapter Three: Three Ways to Be an Exile Badly

Tell a grieving people that their world has ended and they will reach, almost every time, for one of a small number of bad answers, and the exiles in Babylon reached for them too, which is why Jeremiah's letter spends as much energy forbidding the wrong responses as commanding the right one. There were, in Babylon, false prophets, and it is worth knowing what made them false, because they are still with us, wearing new clothes. There was the faction that wanted to fight, that listened to a prophet named Hananiah promising that the yoke of Babylon would be snapped within two years and the whole catastrophe reversed, and there was the quieter faction that wanted simply to disappear, to stop being Jewish, to melt into Babylon until the ache of being different went away. Three bad answers grow from those two roots, and the American church has split, more or less, along exactly these lines, and the tragedy is that each faction is certain the others are the whole problem, and all of them are making a version of the same mistake.

The first bad answer is to fight your way home, to take the country back. If Christendom is falling, this answer says, then the task of the faithful is to hold it up, by force if necessary, to seize the levers of culture and law and the state and crank the old arrangement back into place. This is the impulse behind the harder forms of Christian nationalism, the fusion of cross and flag, the conviction that the way to save the faith is to make the nation Christian again by making it obey. I want to steelman it before I refuse it, because it is not held only by cynics.

Underneath the worst of it there is often a real love, a love of a country and a heritage and a way of life that genuinely gave people good things, and a real grief at watching it dissolve, and a real fear for the children who will grow up in the ruins. Those loves are not nothing, and a church that only sneers at them has not understood the people it is talking about. But name the thing at the root, because the root is rotten even where the grief is real. The take-it-back answer believes that the kingdom of God can be advanced by the sword of Caesar, and the moment it believes that it has lost the ability to tell the two cities apart. It mistakes the nation for the kingdom, baptizes a tribe, and produces a Christianity finally indistinguishable from a voting bloc with a worship band, and you can win every election with that and lose the only thing the church was ever sent to keep.

The second bad answer is to give yourself up, to assimilate. If the culture has moved on, this answer says, then the task of the faithful is to catch up, to quietly file down every edge of the faith the age finds offensive, to keep the architecture and the music and the warm feeling and let the hard substance go. This is the impulse behind the slow accommodation of the progressive church, the steady trade of the difficult sayings of Jesus for the settled opinions of the educated class, and it too deserves a steelman, because it usually presents itself as compassion and sometimes sincerely is, a desire to remove needless offense, to love the people the church has wounded, to stop defending things that were never worth defending. Those instincts are not all wrong. But name the root here too. The give-it-up answer believes that the church survives by agreeing with the world, and a church that agrees with the world about everything has nothing left to say to it and no reason to exist. It will be applauded all the way to its own empty buildings, because the world has never needed a slightly more spiritual version of what it already

believes, and a faith that exists only to bless the going consensus dies the moment the consensus no longer needs its blessing.

The third bad answer is the quietest and the most pious-sounding, and it is to withdraw. If the culture is lost, this answer says, then the task of the faithful is to retreat, to pull back behind the walls, to build a parallel everything and wait out the long darkness in a fortified enclave, protecting the children and the doctrine from a world gone wrong. There is real wisdom mixed into this one, more than the other two, because it takes formation seriously, it knows the culture is catechizing us and wants to build communities thick enough to resist, and some version of strategic withdrawal is genuinely part of faithfulness, as every monastery in history would attest. But pushed to its end it becomes its own betrayal, because it abandons the central command of Jeremiah's letter. The withdrawal answer seeks the welfare of the church and lets the city fend for itself, builds the bunker and calls it discipleship, and forgets that the exiles were sent into Babylon on purpose, for Babylon's sake, and were never given permission to wall themselves off from the city they were commanded to bless. A church that only protects itself has already stopped being the church, because the church was never an end in itself but a people sent for the life of the world.

Now look at what the three answers share, because it is the most important thing in this chapter and it is the thing none of them can see about themselves. All three are driven, underneath the bluster and the compassion and the piety, by the same fear, the fear that the faith cannot survive without the culture's backing. The nationalist cannot imagine a faithful church that is not also a powerful one, so he reaches for power. The accommodationist cannot imagine a faithful church the culture despises, so he reaches for approval. The withdrawer cannot imagine a faithful

church exposed to a hostile world, so he reaches for the wall. Different reaches, same terror. All three have looked at the drained water and concluded that the church cannot live without it, and all three are wrong, and the first three centuries of the church are the proof, and the whole back half of this book will live in that proof. The exiles were not offered any of the three. They were handed a fourth thing, harder than all of them, the thing this book is about, which is to stay, and build, and bless, and remain entirely distinct, in a city they would never control and were commanded to love anyway.

Fight the city, flee the city, or wall yourself off from the city. The three bad answers look like opposites and are secretly the same, because all three are afraid the faith cannot survive without the power it just lost.

I have felt the pull of all three, and I will not pretend otherwise, because the man who has felt only one of them has not been honest with himself. There is a version of me that wants the old deference back, that misses being able to assume the room, that would happily crank the water back on. There is a version of me that wants the clever world's approval, that would love to be the kind of Christian the people who matter find reasonable and unembarrassing. And there is a version of me, on the tired days, that wants only to pull my family behind a wall and let the whole burning city go. All three of those wants are the flesh, and all three are the cultural Christian in me grieving his lost water, and the man who met Christ in the open sea knows better than all three, because he knows the church was born with no power and no approval and no walls, exposed and powerless in the heart of a pagan empire, and it did not merely survive there. It came alive there. It always has. And the letter that tells us how is the same letter the exiles held, which begins by taking away the one thing

all three bad answers are really after, the promise that this will all be over soon.

Chapter Four: Seventy Years

The cruelest word in Jeremiah's letter is a number, and it is the number the exiles least wanted to hear and we least want to hear, which is exactly why both they and we have spent so much energy finding ways around it. When seventy years are completed for Babylon, God says, I will visit you and fulfill to you my promise and bring you back to this place. Seventy years. Not seventy days, not the two short years the popular prophets were promising, but seventy years, which in the ancient world was the far edge of a human lifetime, a span so long that nearly everyone who first heard the letter would die in Babylon, and their children would grow old in Babylon, and only their grandchildren would see the road home. The letter is not a stay of execution. It is a summons to spend a whole life, and to raise a whole generation, in a land they did not choose and could not leave, softened by one promise only, that God would be with them in it, and that at the far end of it, longer than most of them would live, he would bring their descendants home.

To feel the weight of the seventy years you have to set it beside what the people desperately wanted to believe, and there was a prophet glad to supply it. His name was Hananiah, and in the chapter just before the letter he stood up in the temple and prophesied, in the name of the Lord, that within two years God would break the yoke of Babylon, return the plundered temple vessels, and bring the exiled king and all the captives home. It was everything a grieving nation longed for, and it had the full form of faith, spoken with confidence in God's own name, radiant with hope and patriotism and the promise of restoration.

Jeremiah's answer is one of the most poignant moments in all the prophets. He said, in effect, amen, may it be so, nothing would make me happier than for your words to come true. And then he said they would not come true, that Hananiah was making the people trust in a lie, and that the wooden yoke Hananiah had just broken for show would be replaced by a yoke of iron. Hananiah died that same year, as Jeremiah said he would, and the people were left with the prophet who would not comfort them with a falsehood, the one who handed them a shovel where they had wanted a ticket home.

The false prophet of exile is always the one who tells you it will be short, and he is still among us, and he still speaks in the name of the Lord. He tells the grieving church exactly what its grief wants to hear, that the exile is a temporary aberration, that the right election or the right movement or the right revival is about to snap the yoke and crank the old arrangement back into place within a cycle or two, that we are forever on the verge of taking it all back. His appeal is not that he is cynical but that he is merciful in the cheapest way, because he relieves you of the long burden, he lets you stay angry and hopeful and waiting instead of settling down to the slow unglamorous work of faithfulness in a world that is not going to change back on your schedule. And the true prophet is still the one willing to say the harder and lonelier number, that this is not a two-year disruption but a transformation measured in generations, that the cultural home the church held for centuries is not returning in our lifetime or our children's, and that the sooner we make our peace with the seventy years the sooner we can stop waiting for a rescue and start planting a future.

This is what the number exposes about the whole take-it-back project, the thing the last chapter could only point at. Underneath

the anger and the activism and the urgency, the demand to restore Christendom by force is, at its root, a refusal to accept the seventy years. It is the insistence on seeing the harvest in our own lifetime, on being the generation that wins, on a timeline short enough that we personally get to stand in the victory. And that demand, however righteous it feels, has never in the history of the people of God produced anything but false prophets and broken people, because you cannot do multigenerational faithfulness while requiring a one-generation payoff. The seventy years is God's gentle and devastating refusal of our hurry. It tells us that the work is longer than we are, that we will pour out our lives on something we will not see finished, and that this is not the failure of the work but its actual shape among a people whose God has always thought in generations and not in news cycles.

The faithful have always known this, and they have always planted what they would not harvest. Go and look at the monasteries in the centuries after Rome fell, the monks copying the Scriptures by hand in the cold and the dark through what we used to call the dark ages, line after line, year after year, decade after decade, none of them living to see the civilization their patience would one day seed. They did not copy because they could see the harvest. They copied because the word was true and the work was theirs to do and the seeing was God's business and not theirs. That is what it looks like to live inside the seventy years, to give your one life to an orchard whose shade will fall on people you will never meet, to be a faithful link in a chain whose completion you are not promised to witness. The exile cured Israel of the fantasy of the quick return, and in curing it, it produced a people who could be faithful across centuries, which is the only timescale on which anything that matters has ever actually been built.

I want to be careful to separate this from despair, because the prophet of the seventy years is not the prophet of decline. He is not telling the people it is over. He is telling them it is long, which is a completely different word. God keeps his people through the seventy years, all the way through, present in Babylon as surely as he was present in Jerusalem, and the exile turns out to be not the end of Israel's faith but the forge of it, the place where the synagogue is born and the Scriptures are gathered and a portable, durable faith is hammered out that can survive anywhere. But notice the direction the hope faces. The hope of the seventy years is not nostalgia. Nostalgia faces backward, toward the lost country, the old arrangement, the Jerusalem that was, and it spends the exile aching for a return to the past. Biblical hope faces forward, toward the thing God is doing next, the city he is building, the return that is also an advance. The exile who is consumed by nostalgia will waste the seventy years grieving. The exile who has biblical hope will spend them building, because he knows the God who sent him here is also the God going on ahead of him, and that the future, not the past, is where the promise lives.

And this is finally where the famous verse belongs, the one on the coffee mug, restored at last to its actual home. I know the plans I have for you, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. Read it now in its place, as the comfort attached to the seventy-year sentence, and feel how much stronger it is than the private good-luck charm we made of it. God is saying to a people he has just told will spend their lives in exile, I know. I know it is long. I know most of you will not see the end. And I have not forgotten you, my plans for you are plans of shalom and not of harm, there is a future and there is a hope, for a people willing to settle in and trust me through the whole long dark. That is not a promise that your dreams will come true

by spring. It is something far better and far harder, the promise of a God who stays with his people through the seventy years and brings them, in the end, all the way home.

I feel the rebuke of this number in my own chest, because I am a man of my age, formed by its hurry, addicted to its metrics, wanting to see the fruit of my work in my own lifetime and ideally this quarter. I have measured faithfulness by visible results the way the world measures everything, and the seventy years stands over all of it and says no, that is not how my kingdom keeps time. The question the letter puts to us, before it asks us to build or plant or seek or pray, is whether we can bear the seventy years at all, whether we can give our lives to a recovery we will not live to see and call that faithfulness rather than failure. The exiles who could bear it became Daniel in the king's court and Esther in the palace and a people whose witness outlasted the empire that enslaved them. The ones who could not spent their lives waiting for a homecoming that arrived too late for them, and missed the whole strange gift of the years they actually had. The number is seventy. The only question is what you will do with the one life you have inside it.

Chapter Five: Build Houses

When God finally tells the exiles what to do, the first command is so ordinary that its sheer audacity can slip right past you. Build houses and live in them. Not pitch tents. Not throw up anything temporary that can be struck and carried the moment the call to march home finally comes. Houses, with foundations, the kind of thing a man builds only when he has decided, in his bones, that he is staying. To a people straining toward the western horizon for the first sign of rescue, sitting loosely on the land because surely this is temporary, surely we will not be here long, God says the one thing they could not bear to hear. Stay. You live here now. Build something you cannot take with you when you go, because you are not going, not for a very long time, and the sooner your hands admit it the sooner your soul can follow.

A built house is a confession before it is a shelter. It says I am staying, I am exposed, I have decided that this particular patch of a pagan empire is worth the labor and the risk of permanence. And permanence, it turns out, is the precondition of every other thing the letter will go on to ask. You cannot seek the welfare of a city you are about to abandon. You cannot love a neighbor you have walled out or written off as temporary. You cannot raise children in a place or plant a garden in a place or pray with any real investment for a place that you are holding at arm's length, your weight on your back foot, ready to leave the instant the door opens. Everything else in Jeremiah's letter grows out of the soil of this first command, which is the command to put your weight down, to commit to the ground under your feet, to stop

living provisionally in a place God has told you that you will be for the rest of your life.

There are two ways to refuse this command, and the modern church has perfected both. The first is the suitcase. The suitcase Christian keeps his bags by the door, and he has a verse for it, this world is not my home, I am only passing through, and he means it as piety but it functions as an excuse. Why pour myself into the schools of a city under judgment, why invest in the civic life or the long repair of a place I am leaving anyway, why sink roots into ground I do not expect to be standing on much longer. The suitcase looks spiritual and is really a refusal to love what God has commanded me to love, a way of being present in a place without ever being committed to it. The second refusal is the bunker. The bunker Christian also knows he does not belong, but his answer is to wall himself in, to build a fortified parallel world and pull his family and his money and his attention behind the walls and wait for the barbarians to lose interest. Neither one builds a house and lives in it. The suitcase will not invest in Babylon and the bunker will not touch it, and God forbids them both with four plain words. Build houses and live in them.

No one in our time has seen the cost of refusing this command more clearly than the writer Wendell Berry, who has spent a long life arguing, against the whole momentum of the American economy, for the simple and radical act of staying put. Berry says there are two kinds of people, and he calls them boomers and stickers. The boomer treats every place as a resource to be used and a launching pad to somewhere better, moving wherever the opportunity is, extracting what a place offers and leaving when it no longer serves him, loyal to his own advancement and to no particular patch of ground. The sticker is the one who stays, who settles, who commits to a place and its people for the

long haul, who learns a place well enough across years to love it and tend it and be responsible for it. And Berry's hard insight, the one the suitcase and the bunker both evade, is that you cannot love a place in general. You can only love a place in particular. You cannot love your neighbor in the abstract, only this neighbor, on this street, whose name you have bothered to learn because you are not leaving. The exiles are commanded, in effect, to become stickers in Babylon, to love the particular pagan city they have been planted in, not as a cause but as a place, with the patient committed love that only staying makes possible.

This is finally a question of incarnation, and the church should have understood it better than anyone, because our God did not save the world from a safe distance or a temporary visit. He took on flesh and was born in a particular place to a particular family in a particular nation at a particular time, and lived a particular life on particular dusty roads, and that scandalous particularity is the pattern of how God works. He does not love humanity in the abstract. He loves persons, in places, by name. And the church has too often tried to follow an abstract, placeless, mobile Christ who does not exist, a faith of the everywhere and therefore of the nowhere, while the Christ of the Gospels keeps insisting on the local, the particular, the embodied, the parish, the neighbor you can actually touch. To build a house and live in it is to follow the incarnate God into a real place and stay there long enough for your faith to take on flesh, to become not an idea you hold but a life you live among particular people who can watch you live it.

And this cuts hard against the deepest reflexes of American life, because we are the most restless people in the history of the world, a nation built on movement, formed to pull up stakes and go wherever the better job or the bigger house or the fresh start

beckons, optimizing our lives across a map with no particular loyalty to any spot on it. We move, on average, many times in a life, and we have built a whole economy that assumes and rewards it, and the church has largely gone along, so that we now have Christians who change churches as easily as they change neighborhoods, shopping for the better program, the better music, the better fit, loyal to their own preferences and to no particular congregation, treating even the body of Christ as one more place to boom rather than stick. The command to build a house is a command against all of that. It says that there is a faithfulness that can only be learned by staying, a depth that only comes where roots are allowed to grow undisturbed across years, and that the rootless, mobile, optimizing life the culture calls freedom is, for the soul, a kind of homelessness we have mistaken for liberty.

I am not naive about the fact that people must sometimes move, that jobs end and callings change and there are good and necessary reasons a family relocates, and the command to build houses is not a law against ever again packing a truck. It is a posture of the heart before it is a policy about real estate. It is the decision to be fully present and fully committed wherever God has actually planted you, rather than living perpetually on the way to somewhere else, holding your real life in reserve for the better place that is always just ahead. The exile who is always about to leave never really lives anywhere. The exile who builds a house has decided to live here, in this Babylon, with these neighbors, on this street, for as long as God keeps him here, and only that exile can do the rest of what the letter commands, because all of it requires the one thing the suitcase and the bunker both refuse to give. Your weight, set down, on the ground where you actually are. Build the house. And then, the letter says next, do the even harder thing, which is to actually live in it.

Chapter Six: Live in Them

The command does not stop at build. It is build houses and live in them, and the second half is the one we are most likely to skip, because we are people who know how to construct and acquire and improve and are slowly forgetting how to inhabit anything at all. A house is not a worksite and it is not an investment and it is not a project to be optimized. It is a place a human being is meant to live, to eat and sleep and rest and be known, to be a creature among creatures rather than a machine among machines. And the exile who builds the house but never lives in it, who treats even his shelter as one more thing to manage, has obeyed only half the command, and the unobeyed half is the half about being human. To live in the house you have built is to take up residence in your own life, and that turns out to be harder than building, because building is doing and living is being, and we are far better at the first than the second.

Living in the house means, first and most concretely, working in Babylon, because a house has to be paid for, and the exiles did not retreat into a holy enclave funded by nostalgia. They took their place in the ordinary economy of the city that had conquered them. They learned trades and kept accounts and built things and farmed and served the everyday needs of a pagan society and were paid for it, and in doing so they discovered the truth the church keeps having to rediscover and keeps managing to lose, that for a person who belongs to God there is no such thing as secular work. The exile does not have a sacred life on the sabbath and a secular life at the workbench. He has one life, lived before God, and the workbench is as much the place of his

faithfulness as the synagogue, because the God who claims all of him claims his Monday as surely as his Saturday.

The Reformers recovered this with a force we have largely forgotten, and they gave it a name we have turned into a cliché without keeping its substance. Vocation. Luther looked at the medieval arrangement that reserved the word calling for monks and priests, the people who did supposedly spiritual work, and he detonated it. The milkmaid at her pail, he said, and the farmer in his field, and the magistrate at his bench, all of them serve God as truly and as fully as any monk at his prayers, because God is not waiting for them in the religious corner of life but is already present in the work of their hands, feeding the world through the milkmaid and ordering the city through the magistrate. Your work, however ordinary, however invisible, however far from anything that looks religious, is a place where God is at work through you for the good of your neighbor, and to do it well and faithfully is not a distraction from your calling. It is your calling.

Tim Keller spent an entire book on this, arguing that the gospel changes the why and the how and the for-whom of our work, and the argument matters enormously for the exile, because work is where most of us spend most of our waking lives, which means work is where most of our actual discipleship either happens or fails to. The Christian in Babylon does not clock in merely to fund the real Christian life that happens on evenings and weekends, treating forty hours as dead time to be endured for the sake of the few hours that count. He offers the work itself, the spreadsheet and the loading dock and the classroom and the exam room and the sales call, done with integrity and excellence and an eye to the genuine good it does for actual people, as one of the central ways he seeks the welfare of the city. Your cubicle

is one of the houses Jeremiah told you to build. The work you do in Babylon, if it serves the real good of the city and is done as unto God, is not a detour from your faith. It is your faith, with its sleeves rolled up.

This goes back further than the Reformers, all the way to the first pages of the story, where the God who works for six days and calls it good places the human being in a garden and tells him to work it and keep it before there is any such thing as sin to be redeemed from. Work is not a result of the fall. Work is part of what it means to bear the image of a working God, to be a creature who makes and tends and orders and cultivates, who takes the raw material of the world and brings something good out of it the way God brought a world out of the formless deep. The curse did not invent work. It made work hard, frustrating, sweat and thorns, but the thing itself, the dignity of making and tending, was there in Eden and will be there in the new creation, where the picture is not of endless leisure but of a city, which is to say a place of culture and craft and work redeemed. To work, even in Babylon, even under the curse, is to do a deeply human and deeply God-imaging thing.

And this means the dignity of ordinary work has to be recovered against a culture and sometimes a church that despises it. We have built a world that honors a tiny set of glamorous callings, the ones with a platform and a stage and a title, and quietly communicates to everyone else that their work is merely a job, a way to pay the bills until the real significance arrives. But most of what God calls people to will never be on a stage. It will be the faithful raising of children, the honest running of a small business, the patient teaching of a class that will forget your name, the repair of the things that break, the care of the bodies that fail, ten thousand acts of ordinary competence and service

that hold a city together and will never be celebrated. The exile who understands vocation can do that ordinary work with his head up, because he knows that the God he serves is not impressed by stages, that the milkmaid and the magistrate stand on level ground before him, and that a hidden life of faithful ordinary work is not a small thing to God even when it is invisible to everyone else.

But there is a shadow side the exile has to guard against, because work is so good and so God-given that it makes a particularly seductive idol, and the same culture that despises ordinary work also worships work in its prestigious forms. We make our jobs our identity. We answer the question of who we are with the question of what we do. We pour ourselves into our careers as the source of our worth and our meaning, until the work that was meant to be a way of loving our neighbor becomes a way of justifying our existence, and then it devours us, because no job can bear the weight of being a person's god. The exile is called to work hard and well and to refuse, at the same time, to let the work become the thing he lives for, and the discipline that makes that refusal possible is the one built into the very command we are considering, the command to live in the house and not only to build it. Because the antidote to the idolatry of work is the practice of rest.

To live in the house is to rest in it, and the exiles carried into Babylon the strangest and most countercultural practice their God had given them, the practice of stopping. One day in seven they ceased, laid down the work, and remembered that the world was held by God and not by their labor. The sabbath is the proof that work is not their god, the weekly declaration that they are not slaves, that their worth was settled before they produced anything and would remain after they could produce nothing. A

people that cannot stop has not been freed, it has only changed masters, and the exile who builds and works and accumulates without ever resting has not actually moved into his life, he has only relocated his striving from Jerusalem to Babylon. To dwell, to rest, to be present and unhurried in the house you have built, to let a day go by in which you make nothing and prove nothing and simply receive your life as a gift, is its own quiet rebellion against an empire that measures you by your output and would gladly consume every hour you have.

I feel the weight of this command precisely where I am weakest, because I am far better at building than at living, far more comfortable producing than dwelling, and I suspect I am not alone in this, that a whole generation of us has gotten very good at constructing lives we do not actually inhabit. We build the career and the platform and the house and the schedule, and we live perpetually at the edge of our own lives, managing them, optimizing them, anxious about them, never quite resting in them. The command to live in the house is God's mercy to people like me, an instruction to stop building long enough to be human, to take up residence in the one life we have been given, to work as those who are loved rather than those earning their worth, and to rest as those who trust that the world will go on turning while we sleep. Build the house. Then live in it. And the next thing the letter commands, having settled us into a home and a calling, is slower still, and it asks the exile to do the one act that most requires him to believe he is really staying.

Chapter Seven: Plant Gardens

A house you can throw up in a season, but a garden makes you wait, and the waiting is the whole point. You put a seed in the ground and nothing happens for weeks, and if you plant the slow things, the fruit tree, the vine, the orchard, you wait years, and some of what you plant you will not taste for a decade and some of it you will not taste at all. To tell a homesick people straining to go home that they should plant gardens is to tell them a truth their grief cannot bear, that they are going to be here long enough for trees to mature, that this is not a layover but a life. A garden is a bet on staying made with seeds instead of stone, and it is a harder bet than the house, because a house shelters you tonight and a garden asks you to believe in a future you cannot yet see.

This is why the garden is the truest test of whether a person has actually accepted the exile, and not merely endured it while waiting for it to end. The exiles who believed Hananiah, who thought they would be home in two years, would not plant gardens, because you do not dig an orchard into ground you expect to abandon by spring. Only the exile who has heard the word seventy years and let it land, who has stopped waiting for the quick rescue and decided to live the actual life in front of him, will kneel down and put a slow seed into Babylonian dirt. The garden is acceptance with soil under its fingernails. It is the body finally agreeing with what the prophet said, that we are here for the long haul, and that the long haul is not a sentence to be served but a life to be planted and tended and, in time, harvested.

Eugene Peterson built a whole book on a phrase he borrowed, by way of Nietzsche, for exactly this kind of faithfulness, and he called it a long obedience in the same direction. He wrote it against what he named an instant society, a culture of immediacy that has trained us to expect everything now and to abandon anything that does not pay off quickly, and he argued that discipleship is constitutionally the opposite of that, a slow walk in a single direction sustained across a whole life. The garden is the agrarian image of that long obedience. It does not answer to your will or your hurry or your enthusiasm. It answers only to seasons, to patience, to the slow fidelity of someone who keeps tending ground that shows nothing for a long time, who waters and weeds and prunes through the months of apparent nothing because he knows that this is simply how living things grow, underground and unseen, long before there is any fruit to show for it.

The deepest thing the garden teaches is how to plant what you will not harvest, and there is no more countercultural posture available to a modern person. Think of the men who built the great cathedrals of Europe, the masons who laid the foundations of buildings that would take a hundred and fifty years to complete, who quarried and carved and set stone knowing with certainty that they would be dead long before the spire was raised, that they would never once worship in the finished thing their hands had begun. They built anyway. They gave their working lives to a glory they would not live to see, content to be one faithful link in a chain whose completion belonged to God and to generations unborn. That is gardening on the scale of centuries, and it is the exact posture the seventy years requires, the willingness to plant orchards whose shade will fall on faces you will never meet, to labor for a harvest that is not yours to gather.

And this is precisely the posture our age has lost, and the church along with it. We are a people of the launch and the campaign and the metric that has to move this quarter, and we have imported all of it into the life of faith, so that we want revival by next year and a recovered culture by the next election and our own sanctification on a visible schedule. We plant nothing slow because nothing slow shows up in the numbers, and we abandon the ground the moment it fails to produce, and then we wonder why the church feels so frantic and so shallow and so perpetually disappointed. A garden cannot be hurried and cannot be faked and cannot be measured at the speed we measure everything else, and a people that has forgotten how to do anything slowly has forgotten how to do the one thing exile most requires.

I know this impatience from the inside, because it is mine. I want to see the fruit. I want the work of my hands to show results I can point to within a span of time I can stand to wait, and the garden rebukes that want every season, reminding me that the most important things grow on a timeline that has nothing to do with my need to see them. To plant a garden in Babylon is to make peace, in the body, with not being the one who harvests, to give my life to a slow and faithful tending and to leave the increase, as the farmer always must, to God. Plant the garden. Plant the slow things, the things that will not pay you back, the marriage and the children and the church and the long obedience whose fruit you may never taste. And then, having planted, do the thing the same command requires next, which the suitcase Christian and the grim ascetic both forget. Sit down, and eat.

Chapter Eight: Eat Their Produce

The command is not only plant gardens. It is plant gardens and eat their produce, and the second half corrects an error the pious are especially prone to, the assumption that faithfulness in exile means only labor and self-denial and grim endurance, never enjoyment. God tells the exiles to eat. To sit down at the table in Babylon and taste the fruit of the trees they planted, to enjoy the good that even an exile's life produces, to receive the ordinary pleasures of food and harvest and home as gifts and not as guilty compromises with a fallen world. The God who sent them into exile did not send them into a joyless one, and the exile who learns to plant but never to eat, who treats every pleasure as a distraction from the real work, has misunderstood the command as badly as the one who never plants at all.

There are two ways to fail at eating the produce, and the exile is tempted by both. The first is the failure of the suitcase Christian, who is too busy waiting to leave to ever really enjoy where he is, who holds the goods of this life at arm's length because they are not the goods of home, who cannot taste the bread of Babylon because his heart is always somewhere else. He is so spiritual about his exile that he refuses its legitimate joys, and he calls his refusal holiness, when often it is only a failure to receive what God has actually given. The second failure is the opposite, the failure of the glutton, who consumes endlessly and tastes nothing, who is so busy reaching for the next thing that he never enjoys the thing in his hand, whose overconsumption is its own kind of inability to eat, because real eating requires presence and gratitude and a capacity for enough, and the glutton has none of

these. One is too pious to enjoy the produce and the other too greedy to taste it, and both have failed the simple command to eat.

The cure for both is gratitude, the settled and grateful enjoyment of ordinary good as the gift of God. Paul told Timothy that everything created by God is good and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving, and the Preacher in Ecclesiastes, having stared into every vanity under the sun, kept returning to the same hard-won counsel, that there is nothing better for a person than to eat and drink and find enjoyment in his toil, and that this too is from the hand of God. This is not a lesser, fleshly wisdom set against the spiritual life. It is the spiritual life, the recognition that the God who made a world of bread and wine and fruit and harvest means for his people to receive these things with open hands and grateful hearts, even in exile, especially in exile, as foretastes of his goodness and signs that he has not abandoned them to mere survival.

So the exiles ate. They ate Babylonian bread and drank from vines they had planted in foreign soil, and they gave thanks over it, and in the thanksgiving the food of exile became something more than fuel, it became communion, a daily sacrament of the truth that God provides for his people even in the land of their captivity. You can receive real good from a place that is not your home. You can taste genuine sweetness in a life you did not choose. The fruit of the garden you planted in Babylon is no less a gift of God because Babylon is not Jerusalem, and to eat it with gratitude is to declare that God is good and present and generous even here, even now, even in exile, which is a more powerful witness to a watching pagan neighbor than any amount of grim and joyless endurance could ever be.

There is also a forward-looking joy in the eating, because the

produce of the garden is a foretaste and not only a present pleasure. Every harvest the exile gathers in Babylon is a small downpayment on the great harvest to come, a sign that the God who gives fruit now will give the fuller fruit at the end, that the table in exile is a rehearsal for the feast in the kingdom. To eat the produce with joy is to practice, in the body, the hope of the homecoming, to taste in the ordinary fruit of an ordinary garden a small sure sample of the goodness that waits at the end of the seventy years. The exile does not have to wait until the return to taste that God is good. He can taste it now, at the table he has set in the middle of Babylon, and the tasting is itself an act of faith.

I have to preach this one to myself from the other side than most, because my temptation is not the glutton's but the striver's, the inability to stop laboring long enough to enjoy what the labor produced, the suspicion that rest and pleasure are indulgences I have not earned. The command to eat the produce is God's gentle correction of that grim and joyless faithfulness, the reminder that he did not plant his people in Babylon only to work but also to live, and that a life with no joy in it, no table, no feast, no grateful tasting of ordinary good, is not the holy life I imagine it to be but a quiet refusal of the gifts of God. Plant the garden, and then sit down and eat its fruit with thanksgiving, because the God of exile is a God who sets a table even here. And the richest fruit the exile is commanded to plant and to enjoy is not the vegetable in the ground at all. It is the family at the table, the marriage and the children that are the exile's deepest planting and his boldest bet on a future he may never live to see.

Chapter Nine: Take Wives, Raise Children

The next command is the most defiant in the whole letter, though it does not look defiant, because it wears the most ordinary clothes imaginable. Take wives and have sons and daughters, God tells the exiles, take wives for your sons and give your daughters in marriage, so that they too may have sons and daughters. Marry. Have children. Raise them to marry and have children of their own. To a defeated and demoralized people, sitting in the wreckage of their nation, God commands the most hopeful and most stubborn act a human being can perform, the founding of a household and the having of children, and he commands it precisely as an act of defiance against despair.

Understand what decline does to a defeated people, because it is the natural gravity the command resists. The defeated stop having children. Why bring a child into a lost cause, why marry into the same exile that broke you, why give your daughter to face the captivity you are enduring, why invest in a future you have stopped believing in. The natural posture of a conquered people is contraction, a slow giving-up that expresses itself first in the refusal to build families, and against exactly that despair God speaks his most pointed word in the letter. Multiply there, and do not decrease. Do not let the line thin out and die in Babylon. The exile is not a reason to stop the future. It is the place the future will now be made, and the making of it begins in the founding of households that refuse to believe the story is over.

This is because the home is the first and most durable outpost of

the people of God in any foreign land, the smallest and strongest unit of the faith's survival and transmission. Long before there was a temple to lose, there was a family at a table, and the central command for passing on the faith was given not to priests in a sanctuary but to parents in a house. These words shall be on your heart, God told them, and you shall teach them diligently to your children, and talk of them when you sit in your house and when you walk by the way and when you lie down and when you rise. The faith was always meant to be transmitted at close range, parent to child, in the texture of ordinary domestic life, around the table and along the road and at the edge of sleep, and in exile that transmission becomes the whole ballgame, because the surrounding culture will no longer carry it for you.

That last point is the hinge, and it changes everything about how seriously the exile must take his own household. In Christendom the home could afford to be lazy about formation, because the school and the town and the very air carried the faith alongside the parents, reinforcing at every turn what was taught at home. In Babylon the air carries something else. Your children are being catechized all day long, by the screen and the school and the feed and a thousand small liturgies of a city that worships other gods, and the only question is whether anything happening at your own table is strong enough to compete. The family that does not actively, deliberately, relentlessly form its children in the faith is not staying neutral. It is conceding the field, handing its children to Babylon's catechesis by default, and then wondering why they grew up to believe what Babylon believes.

This is why marriage itself has to be recovered as a covenant and not a contract, and I have written a whole book on that battle, so here I will only set it in the frame of exile. A culture organized around the sovereign self treats marriage as a deal that lasts as

long as it serves me, and a deal cannot bear the weight the exile needs marriage to bear, because forming children and witnessing to a watching city both require something that does not quit when it stops being convenient. The exiles were told to build their marriages and their children into Babylon as a permanent presence, and permanence is precisely what the surrounding culture can no longer imagine or sustain. A marriage that actually keeps its vows, in plain sight, across decades, through the seasons when it costs more than it returns, is one of the loudest sermons a Christian household can preach in an age of the disposable, and the watching neighbor who cannot account for it is hearing the gospel preached in a language deeper than words.

And the raising of children in exile is not mainly a matter of rules or shelter but of formation, of slowly forming a child who knows in his bones a different and truer story than the one Babylon is telling him. This happens less through lectures than through liturgies, the repeated practices of a household, the family meal that is guarded and unhurried, the prayers said together at the hinges of the day, the worship that gathers the household around the Scriptures, the rhythms of feast and fast and sabbath that teach a child what time is for and whose he is. It happens through a home that is itself a small contrast society, visibly running on a different physics than the world outside its door, so that the child grows up having tasted, in the most formative place there is, a way of life he will recognize later as the kingdom. The home is not the delivery mechanism for a message about the faith. The home is where the faith is first lived, or first betrayed.

I am a father, and I will not pretend I stand outside the undertow I am describing, because every Christian parent in this country

feels the same current pulling at their children, the pressure to outsource their formation to people and devices better funded and more relentless than we are. The letter does not hand us a strategy for winning that fight at the level of the whole culture. It hands us something more modest and more powerful, the command to make our own homes the first place the kingdom is visible, to multiply and not decrease, to raise children who carry a different story out into Babylon as the next generation of faithful exiles. That is not retreat into the family and it is not the bunker. It is the family as the seedbed of everything else the letter commands, the place where the people who will seek the welfare of the city are themselves formed, one ordinary household at a time. Babylon is downstream of ten thousand kitchen tables, and so is the church that will outlast it.

Chapter Ten: Multiply, Do Not Decrease

There is a phrase tucked into the family command that deserves its own consideration, because it is where the household opens out onto the long future of the whole people of God. Multiply there, and do not decrease. It is a word about generations, about the transmission of the faith across time, about whether the people of God in exile will dwindle and disappear or endure and grow, and it locates the answer not in strategy or program but in the ordinary fruitfulness of faithful households across generations. The future of the faith in Babylon, God says, will be carried not by the impressive and the powerful but by the patient multiplication of families who raise children who raise children, a chain of transmission as unglamorous as it is decisive.

I want to be careful here, because this command has a weaponized counterfeit, and I do not mean the counterfeit. There is a politics that hears multiply and do not decrease as a demographic strategy, a call to outbreed the opposition and win the future by sheer numbers, and it turns children into ammunition in a culture war and the family into a front line. That is not what the letter means and it is not what I mean. The fruitfulness God commands the exiles is not a demographic weapon but an act of hope, the refusal of a defeated people to give up on the future, the quiet defiance of households who keep believing the story is worth handing on even when the surrounding world has written that story off. The point is not to win Babylon by numbers. The point is to refuse the despair that stops a conquered people from believing there should be a next

generation at all.

The early church understood fruitfulness in exactly this hopeful and not strategic way, and it is worth remembering how it actually grew, because it did not grow mainly by argument or by conquest. It grew, in large part, the way the exiles were told to grow, through families, through the steady patient transmission of the faith from parents to children across generations, and through an astonishing openness to the children no one else wanted. In a Roman world that routinely exposed unwanted infants on the hillside to die, mostly the girls, the Christians went out and gathered them up and raised them as their own, multiplying their households not only by birth but by mercy, refusing to let a child be discarded. The church grew because it cherished life and welcomed children in a culture that treated both as disposable, and its fruitfulness was inseparable from its reverence for the very lives the empire threw away.

And the hard lesson buried in do not decrease is that the church most often shrinks not through persecution from outside but through failed transmission within, through a generation that holds the faith and fails to hand it on. We have watched this happen in our own time, congregations that kept their children busy with programs and entertainment but never actually formed them, that assumed the faith would pass to the next generation automatically the way it had under Christendom, and then watched those children grow up and walk away, catechized more deeply by the culture than by the church that had merely amused them. The exile cannot afford that complacency. In a hostile age the faith passes to the next generation only where it is deliberately, lovingly, relentlessly transmitted, and a church that does not take the formation of its own children with deadly seriousness will not be persecuted out of existence. It will simply

fail to reproduce, and decrease, one unformed child at a time.

So multiply and do not decrease is finally a word of hope set against the gravity of despair, a command to keep planting people in the soil of Babylon, to keep raising children in the faith and welcoming them into the household of God, to keep believing that there will be a generation after this one worth handing the gospel to. The exile who obeys it is making the same bet as the man who plants the slow orchard, the bet that the future is worth investing in even though he will not see most of it, that the children he raises and the children they raise are the form his faithfulness takes across a time he will not live to see. Do not decrease. Keep the line alive. Hand on what you were given, because the faith is always one generation from extinction and always one faithful household from another hundred years.

Chapter Eleven: Seek the Welfare of the City

Now we reach the line the whole letter has been building toward, the command that sits at the dead center of everything, and it should still be able to shock us the way it must have shocked the first people who heard it. Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare. Not your own welfare. The city's. The flourishing of Babylon, the empire that razed Jerusalem and dragged you here in chains. Seek its good. Work for its thriving. Want it to prosper. This is not the kind of thing anyone says to a conquered people, and it is the opposite of what every conquered people has ever wanted to hear, and it stands at the center of the Christian life in exile like a sun the rest of the planets move around.

We have to feel how scandalous it is before we can obey it. The natural posture of an exile toward the city that conquered him is one of two things, and we have met them both already. Either he wants Babylon to fall, nursing its coming judgment, refusing to lift a finger for the welfare of the place that humiliated him, or he wants into Babylon, envying it, ready to trade his strange identity for a comfortable seat at its table. God forbids both and commands a third thing neither the resentful nor the assimilated can imagine. Pour yourself out for the good of the city. Make it more just, more whole, more flourishing, precisely as a people who belong entirely to someone else. The exile is to be the best citizen Babylon has, not despite belonging to another kingdom but because of it, seeking the earthly city's welfare with a

freedom only those whose deepest hope lies elsewhere can manage.

The word translated welfare is shalom, and everything depends on hearing it at full strength rather than in the thin sense we have shrunk it to. Shalom is not merely the absence of conflict or a private inner peace. It is wholeness, the way things are supposed to be when they are right, a richly textured flourishing that touches every part of a common life. A city has shalom when the hungry are fed and the worker is paid fairly and the stranger is safe and the vulnerable are protected and the sick are tended and neighbors know one another and the weak are not crushed under the strong. To seek the shalom of the city is to seek all of that, the full flourishing of the actual place, for the good of the actual people in it, and not merely to seek a quiet space in which to practice your private religion undisturbed. It is a robust, public, demanding command, and it sends the exile out into the life of the city as an agent of its wholeness.

James Davison Hunter gave this posture a name a generation ago that has stuck because it is right, and he called it faithful presence. He set it against the church's three failed postures toward the culture, the defensive posture that is always against the world, the relevant posture that is desperate to be accepted by it, and the purity posture that wants only to withdraw from it. Over against all three he set faithful presence, the slow patient committed labor for the genuine good of the actual place, carried out by people whose hope is anchored somewhere the place cannot reach and who are therefore free to love it without needing it to save them. That is the shape of seeking the city's welfare. Not against Babylon, not assimilated to Babylon, not hidden from Babylon, but faithfully present within it, working for its shalom as those who belong to another city and are

therefore free to spend themselves on this one.

And then comes the promise that binds the whole thing together and turns the command from mere altruism into something stranger and surer. In its welfare you will find your welfare. God ties the flourishing of the exiles to the flourishing of the city so tightly that the two cannot be pulled apart, so that when they seek Babylon's good they are, in the deepest sense, seeking their own. This is not a bribe and it is not selfishness baptized. It is a statement about how God has actually ordered the world, that the people who pour themselves out for the good of the place they live in will find their own lives bound up in its flourishing, and that the attempt to secure your own welfare while ignoring the city's is not only disobedient but futile, because your welfare was never separable from the welfare of the place God planted you. Seek the city's good and you will find your own waiting there. Hoard your own and you will lose both.

The quiet indictment in all of this falls on us, and it is the heaviest in the book so far. The American church, by and large, has not been seeking the welfare of the city. It has been seeking its own welfare, its own power and market share and comfort and protection, and it has too often treated the actual city, with its actual poor and actual strangers and actual lonely, as either a threat to be feared or a mission field to be harvested, rarely as a neighbor whose flourishing we are simply commanded to want. And then we wonder why our witness rings hollow, why the city does not believe we love it, and the answer is that for the most part we have not loved it, we have used it or feared it or tried to rule it, while the one thing we were actually commanded to do, to seek its good and pray for its peace, we left undone. The command is not complicated. It is only costly. And it has a specific shape, a particular set of people it bends toward first,

which is where the letter and the whole witness of Scripture take us next.

Chapter Twelve: The Poor, the Stranger, the Neighbor

The welfare of a city is not an abstraction, and Scripture never lets it stay one. When God commands the exiles to seek the shalom of Babylon, he is commanding something with a particular shape and a particular bias, because the whole witness of the law and the prophets insists that the health of a community is measured at its margins, by what is happening to the people who cannot defend themselves. The flourishing of a city is not measured by its powerful but by its vulnerable, by the poor and the stranger and the widow and the orphan, the people God names again and again as the test of whether a society is whole. To seek the welfare of the city is therefore to seek, first and most particularly, the good of the people the city is most tempted to overlook.

I have written a separate book on what the church has forgotten about the poor, so I will not lay the whole biblical case out again here, but it belongs in the exile's hands as part of what seeking the city's shalom must mean. The God who heard the cry of slaves in Egypt has never stopped bending toward the bottom of the world, and a people who claim that God while ignoring the cry he is famous for hearing have not understood the welfare they are commanded to seek. Seeking the shalom of Babylon means feeding its hungry and defending its weak and tending its sick and welcoming its strangers, not as an optional addendum to the real work of the church but as the concrete form the command actually takes when it touches the ground.

The early church understood this with a clarity that shamed an empire, and the way it sought the welfare of its hostile city is the pattern the exile is given. When the great plagues swept the Roman world and the cities filled with the dying, the pagan response was the rational one, to flee, to leave the sick by the road even when they were your own, because to stay was to risk death. And the Christians stayed. They nursed the sick, their own and their pagan neighbors alike, at staggering cost to themselves, and the watching world could not comprehend it and could not forget it, and the city's welfare was served by exiles who had every reason to let it die and chose instead to spend themselves for its life. They sought the shalom of a city that despised them, and the seeking was the most persuasive sermon the ancient world ever heard.

There is a particular poverty the exile is positioned to address in our own moment, and it is the poverty of isolation, the fraying of the bonds that once held neighbors to one another. The sociologist Robert Putnam spent a famous book documenting how thoroughly we have come apart at this seam, how the clubs and the congregations and the simple habits of neighborliness have emptied out until we live and age and die among strangers, and the decades since have only deepened the loneliness he found. Into that fraying the command to seek the city's welfare drops with fresh and concrete force. Be the neighbor Babylon forgot how to be. Learn the names on your street. Open your table. Tend the lonely and the elderly and the overlooked, not as a program but as the ordinary fabric of a life lived for the good of the actual place, because a city dying of isolation is a city whose shalom is exactly the thing the exile is sent to seek.

And this seeking belongs to neither political tribe and will be captured by neither, which is precisely why the church must

recover it as its own. One side has made the care of the poor and the stranger into a partisan program and the other has made it into a partisan suspicion, and both have handed the church an excuse to ignore half of what God commands while feeling righteous about the half they kept. The exile takes the whole command, the poor and the stranger and the neighbor and the vulnerable, not because a party tells him to but because the God who sent him into the city told him to seek its shalom, and shalom has always had this shape and this bias, toward the bottom, toward the margins, toward the people the powerful overlook. Seek the welfare of the city, and you will find yourself, every time, drawn first toward the very people the city has forgotten.

Chapter Thirteen: Pray for the City

The command to seek the city's welfare does not end with our hands. It ends on our knees. Seek the welfare of the city, and pray to the Lord on its behalf. God tells the exiles to pray for Babylon, and this small addition does something the activism alone could never do, because it goes to work not only on the city but on the one who prays. You can seek a city's good for a while out of grim duty, with the old resentment still simmering underneath, but you cannot pray for a city, by name, day after day, year after year, and go on hating it. Prayer for Babylon is the instrument God uses to dismantle the exile's bitterness from the inside, and it is the most active thing the exile does, not the passive alternative to action but the practice that forms him into the kind of person who can do everything else without poison in his heart.

Consider how hard the thing actually being asked is. Pray for the prosperity of the regime that burned the temple. Ask God to bless the city that took your freedom and your home. There is no harder prayer in the Old Testament, and there is none more clarifying, because it forces the exile to settle the deepest question of all, whether Babylon is his enemy to be cursed or his assignment to be blessed. The whole letter has already answered. Babylon is not the enemy. It is the city God himself has sent his people into, on purpose, for a reason, and the proof that the exile has understood that is whether he can pray for its good and mean it. To pray for the city is to take its needs and its rulers and its lost and its poor before the throne of the God it does not know, standing between Babylon and heaven as a kind of priest for a

city that has no idea it is being prayed for.

This is where the interior life and the public life finally meet, and it is why prayer can never be the passive option set against real engagement. Prayer for the city is the practice that forms the one who prays into someone capable of all the rest, because you cannot build and plant and seek the welfare of a place you secretly despise, not for a lifetime, not without the resentment eventually poisoning everything you touch. The daily discipline of lifting Babylon before God, by name, with its genuine needs and its real brokenness, slowly turns the captive into someone who loves the city he was planted in, and a person who loves the city will seek its welfare with a freedom and a tenderness that grim duty could never produce. We are formed by what we repeatedly do, and the exile who prays for his city every day will find, over time, that he has come to love it, which is the miracle the command was designed to work.

There is also a kind of intercession in this that holds two things together that we are tempted to pull apart, the blessing of the city and the resistance to its evil. To pray for the welfare of Babylon is not to pretend Babylon is good, and the same prophets who told the exiles to seek the city's peace also thundered against the city's injustice and idolatry. The exile prays for the city and against everything in the city that destroys shalom, asks God to bless it and to heal exactly the brokenness that blessing would mean, holds its flourishing and its repentance together in a single petition. You can want a place to be saved and want its evils to end in the same breath, and that is what mature intercession actually is, neither the naive blessing that ignores the wrong nor the bitter cursing that abandons the place, but the costly prayer that wants the city whole, which means wanting it both forgiven and changed.

And the promise that crowned the command crowns the prayer as well. In its welfare you will find your welfare. The exile's prayer for Babylon is not a selfless act of spiritual heroism that costs him everything and returns nothing, because God has bound the exile's flourishing to the city's, so that when he prays for Babylon he is, in the deepest sense, praying for himself and his children and the whole fragile life he is building there. The man who prays for his city has stopped living as its victim and started living as its priest, and he has discovered the strange freedom of a person whose own good is no longer something he has to seize and defend but something he can trust God to supply as he spends himself in prayer for the good of others. Pray for the city until you love it. And then, having loved it enough to bless it and pray for it and seek its welfare with everything you have, do the one thing that keeps all of that from curdling into surrender, the thing that marks the difference between an exile who blesses Babylon and an exile who has simply become a Babylonian. Refuse, when the moment comes, to bow.

Chapter Fourteen: Do Not Bow

Every command in the letter so far has been a movement toward Babylon. Build into it. Plant in it. Raise families in it. Seek its welfare. Pray for its good. And every one of those movements carries the same danger, the danger that in drawing so near to the city we will be absorbed by it, that seeking Babylon's welfare will slide by imperceptible degrees into becoming a Babylonian, that the salt will dissolve into the very thing it was sent to season. A people commanded to love the city so thoroughly needs a guardrail against loving it too much, against loving it in the wrong way, against the slow assimilation that begins as engagement and ends as surrender. And Scripture gives that guardrail a face and a name. His name is Daniel, and he is the master class in the one thing this whole book has been circling. How to seek a city's good without bowing to its gods.

Watch what Daniel does, because it is both of the things we are forever tempted to pull apart. He serves Babylon with such excellence that pagan king after pagan king promotes him, trusts him, leans on him, a Hebrew exile running the administration of the very empire that destroyed his nation. He is not in the bunker. He is not keeping his bags packed by the door. He has built houses and sought the welfare of the city about as far as a man can, rising to the top of Babylon's government and using his position for the good of the realm. And then, when the law commands that everyone bow to the king's image or pray only to the king, Daniel does the thing that defines him and defines the whole vocation of the exile. He will not bow. He serves the city with everything he has, and he worships it with nothing, and he

holds those two together across a long life without ever letting either one swallow the other.

That is the line, and it is the line the exile must be able to find in the dark, because it will not always be obvious where seeking the city's good ends and bowing to the city's gods begins. Serve Babylon, yes, to the hilt, with excellence and loyalty and genuine love. Worship Babylon, never, not its idols, not its ultimate loyalties, not the things it demands you treat as absolute. The exile is a citizen of the earthly city and a subject of another kingdom at the same time, and the whole art of living well in Babylon is keeping those two allegiances in their proper order, giving the city his labor and his love and his prayers while reserving his worship for the God who sent him into it. Seek the welfare of the city with all your strength. And when the city asks for the one thing that belongs to God alone, refuse.

The American church has been catastrophically bad at holding this line, and it has failed in a particularly humiliating way, because it has gotten Daniel exactly backwards. Daniel sought the city and would not bow. We have tended to bow while refusing to seek. We have bent the knee to Babylon's actual gods, to the nation, to the market, to the self, to the outrage and the comfort and the consumer appetite that the surrounding culture worships, quietly adopting the city's ultimate loyalties as our own, until our Christianity became barely distinguishable from Babylonian religion with a cross laid over the top. And at the very same time we have refused to seek the city's welfare, treating Babylon as an enemy to be defeated or a threat to be feared rather than a place to be blessed. We got both halves wrong at once. We bow to the gods we were supposed to refuse, and we withhold the love we were supposed to give, which is the exact inversion of Daniel and the worst of both possible exiles.

To refuse to bow, you first have to know what you are being asked to worship, and this is harder than it sounds, because the gods of an age are mostly invisible to the people who serve them. They do not announce themselves as idols. They feel like common sense, like the obvious way to see things, like reality itself. The most important discernment the exile ever does is learning to see the loyalties he has absorbed without choosing them, the assumptions handed to him by his culture and mistaken for the faith, the political and economic and national and individualist reflexes that he treats as Christian because he has never examined them. This is why theological depth is not a luxury for the exile but a survival skill. A shallow faith cannot tell the difference between Christ and Babylon dressed up as Christ, and so it bows without ever knowing it has bowed, worshipping the age's gods in the sincere belief that it is worshipping the living God. Only a faith that has gone down to the root, that knows the Scriptures and the creeds and the long memory of the church, can stand in Babylon and tell the two apart.

So the exile has to become a discerner, a person who has done the hard interior work of finding the Babylon inside himself, the loyalties and the appetites and the assumptions that the city installed in him below the level of his awareness. And this is uncomfortable, because it means the enemy is not only out there in the culture but in here, in my own captured heart, in the ways I have already bowed without noticing, the ways my Christianity has been quietly conscripted to serve the city's gods. The refusal to bow begins not at the public moment of testing but in the daily, unglamorous work of examining my own loves, asking which of them are Christ's and which are Babylon's, and letting the ones that belong to the city be pried loose from the worship that belongs to God alone. You cannot refuse to bow to an idol

you cannot see, and the first idols the exile has to see are the ones already sitting on the throne of his own heart.

Chapter Fifteen: The Windows Open

There is a detail in Daniel's story that tells you everything about how the refusal to bow actually works, and it is a matter of windows. When the law was passed forbidding prayer to anyone but the king, Daniel did not organize a resistance and he did not go into hiding. He went home, to his upper room, where the windows opened toward Jerusalem, and he got down on his knees three times a day and prayed and gave thanks to his God, as he had done before. The windows were open. He did not hide his faithfulness and he did not brandish it, he simply continued it, in plain sight, as though the law had not been passed, and he took the lions' den as the price without flinching. That is the shape of holy refusal. Not concealment, not rebellion, just quiet continued faithfulness with the windows open, the ordinary practice of a life given to God carried on in full view whatever it costs.

His three friends show the same thing from the other side, in the more famous scene, when the whole assembly is commanded to fall down and worship the golden image and they will not. Their answer to the furious king is one of the great statements of faith in all of Scripture, and it holds two things together that our fear always wants to separate. Our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, they say, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image you have set up. If he saves us, we will not bow. And if he does not save us, we still will not bow. Their refusal is not contingent on rescue. They do not obey God because they are

sure it will work out. They obey God because he is God, and they leave the outcome, deliverance or death, entirely in his hands, and either way the answer to Babylon is the same. We will not bow.

This is the freedom that only a settled worship can produce, and it is the freedom the exile most needs and most lacks. The three could refuse the image because their worship was already given, fully and finally, to another, so that Babylon had nothing left to threaten them with, because the thing it wanted, their ultimate allegiance, was not theirs to give, it had already been spent on God. A person whose worship is unsettled, who has kept a little of it in reserve for the nation or the market or his own survival, can always be moved, because Babylon can always find the price. But a person whose worship is wholly God's is immovable, not because he is brave but because there is nothing left to bargain with, the deepest loyalty is already committed, and all Babylon can do is kill him, which turns out to be the one threat that has no power over a people who believe in resurrection. The martyrs were not the church's failures. They were its freest members, the ones Babylon could not move because their worship was already given away.

And so we arrive at the thing that keeps the whole vocation of the exile from collapsing into either of its opposite errors, and it is worth stating as plainly as the letter states it. The exile is not the culture warrior who fights the city and bows to its idols, giving Babylon his worship while withholding his love. And the exile is not the assimilated believer who blesses the city by becoming indistinguishable from it, dissolving his distinctness into the surrounding culture until there is nothing left to bless it with. The exile is Daniel, who sought the welfare of the city with everything he had and would not, for anything, bow, who served

Babylon and worshipped only God, who kept the windows open and took the lions as the price. That is the figure the whole letter has been forming, the one who can love the city precisely because he does not worship it, who can seek its good precisely because his good is not finally found in it, who is free to spend himself for Babylon because his life is hidden with God and Babylon cannot touch it.

Keeping the windows open is not a single dramatic act but a daily one, and this is the last thing to say about the refusal to bow. Daniel's faithfulness in the great crisis was possible only because of the ten thousand ordinary days of faithfulness that came before it, the prayers said three times a day for a lifetime, the small disciplines and refusals that had already formed him into the kind of person who would not bow when it counted. You do not decide, in the moment of testing, to be the person who refuses. You become that person slowly, through years of small faithfulness with the windows open, so that when the furnace is finally lit the refusal is not a heroic exertion of the will but the natural expression of a life already given. The exile who wants to stand in the great moment must give himself to God in the small ones, keeping his own windows open day after unremarkable day, so that his worship is settled long before Babylon ever asks for it, and there is simply nothing left in him that could bow.

Coda: In Its Welfare, Your Welfare

We began with a verse on a coffee mug, and it is time to give it back its full weight, because the whole letter has been quietly building toward it. I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. We have read that as a private promise of personal good fortune, and in doing so we have missed the single most important word in it, because the word translated welfare is the same word, shalom, that stands three verses earlier in the command to seek the welfare of the city. It is not a coincidence and it is not a coffee mug. The shalom God plans to give you in the eleventh verse is bound, by the deliberate repetition of one Hebrew word, to the shalom he commands you to seek for the city in the seventh. Your welfare and the city's welfare are the same welfare. He said it twice, with the same word, on purpose, so that we could not finally pull them apart.

This is the whole letter, and the whole of this book, gathered into a single sentence. The plans God has for your good are not a promise that he will lift you out of Babylon into a private prosperity of your own. They are the promise that as you seek the good of the city he has planted you in, you will find your own good waiting there, hidden inside the welfare of the place you were sent to bless. You will not find your shalom by hoarding it behind a wall, or by waiting out the exile with your bags packed, or by dissolving into Babylon until there is no self left to flourish. You will find it the way the letter said you would, by building and planting and marrying and raising and seeking and praying and refusing to bow, by spending your one life on

the welfare of a city that is not your home, until the day you discover that in seeking its life you were given your own.

So this is what it means to live well, and it is why the platform this book belongs to carries that name. To live well is not to escape the exile. It is not to end it early by force or to make peace with it by surrender. To live well is to seek the welfare of the city where God has sent you, because in its welfare you will find your welfare. It is the ordinary verbs of an ordinary exile life, held together across a lifetime. Build the house and live in it. Plant the garden you may not harvest, and eat its fruit with thanksgiving. Marry, and raise children who know a better story, and do not let the line thin out in despair. Seek the flourishing of the poor and the stranger on your street. Pray for the city until you love it. And keep your windows open toward the true city, and do not bow. That is not a strategy for surviving until the good life resumes somewhere else. That is the good life. It always was.

I will not end by promising you that the exile is nearly over, because Jeremiah did not, and the prophets who promise a short exile are the ones who have always turned out to be lying. The number is still seventy years. It is still a lifetime. You and I will very likely die in Babylon, with the gardens we planted bearing fruit for people we will never meet, and the recovery of a deep and faithful church still unfinished in our hands. But the God who wrote the letter did not send his people into exile and then withdraw to wait for them at the border. He went with them, into Babylon, into the furnace, into the lions' den, into the long captivity, and he is with his exiles still, in the houses and the gardens and the marriages and the prayers, in the daily unglamorous labor for the welfare of a city that does not yet know his name. The exile is not the place where the good life is

suspended until the return. For the people of God it has nearly always been the place where the good life is finally learned, stripped of its scaffolding, down to the rock, with nothing left to stand on but him.

So build your house. Plant your garden. Take a wife, raise your children, seek the welfare of the city, pray for its peace, and keep the windows open. Do not wait for Babylon to become Jerusalem, and do not pretend that it already is. Live, fully and faithfully and without fear, in the city you did not choose, for the sake of a God the city does not know, and trust him with the seventy years and with the homecoming at the end of them. Seek the welfare of the city. And in its welfare, exactly where the letter promised it would be, you will find your own.